In what ways could extended school residencies at the museum be enhanced in the future?

Some Recommendations…

Recommendation 1: training in the use of collections and resources to teach the national curriculum

The entire museum infrastructure offers a wealth of opportunities for the teaching of literacy and numeracy - the building itself, behind the scenes storage, the shop and café facilities, as well as the collections themselves. Prior to the project, there was no training for schools or museums on how to maximise the learning opportunities of objects and collections. Although there were some innovations tailored to particular student groups, in general, the museums relied on existing educational programmes.

Recommendation 2: develop bespoke resources for developing literacy in the museum

In general, teachers noticed a marked improvement in the children's speaking skills. However, they also recorded decreased literacy scores in some areas. This is surprising as there is evidence that literacy skills can be improved by using museum and gallery collections as a key motivational prompt for writing. Schools and museums develop bespoke resources for literacy in particular, drawing on learning from other museum based educational projects.

Recommendation 2: widen the educational focus of collections

Initially, teachers found it difficult to extend the focus of their teaching beyond the most obvious links to history and art. By working more collaboratively with museums on delivering all of the curriculum, teachers will be enabled to take full advantage of their collections and resources to incorporate a broader range of the curriculum in the museum setting.

Recommendation 3: co-create educational experiences

Although some of the sessions in this project were co-created, for the majority of the time, sessions where designed and delivered by museum and school staff. Extended residencies offer the opportunity to engage with children more deeply and meaningfully - for example through their involvement in the development of new exhibitions - not just as consumers of culture but as co-creators and facilitators.

Recommendation 4: engage all museum staff in educational visits

The pilot highlighted the need to involve all museum staff and volunteers in educational visits and to impress upon them the valuable role all staff play in enriching the children's experience. In our project, some front-of-house staff were initially concerned about the potential noise and disturbance that could be caused by the extended visits.

[Box out]
"Make sure that the front of house staff and other internal stakeholders are fully on board with why you are doing what you're re doing and its importance."
Virginia Wilkinson, Learning Officer, North and South Tyneside

Recommendation 5: ensure understanding of organisational cultures and effective communication

Extended residencies require both schools and museums to understand each other's organisational cultures. In some cases a lack of practical knowledge led to communication difficulties. Whole organisation briefings at the start of and throughout a project would foster internal advocacy both within the school and the museum in the future.

Recommendation 6: use of outdoor spaces

Although the majority of children enjoyed playtime outside of the museum buildings, outdoor spaces could be used more extensively in the future.

"It just puts a smile on everybody's face seeing 16 three-year-olds trotting in and out every day"
Deborah Riding, Programme Manager, Children and Young People, Tate Liverpool